

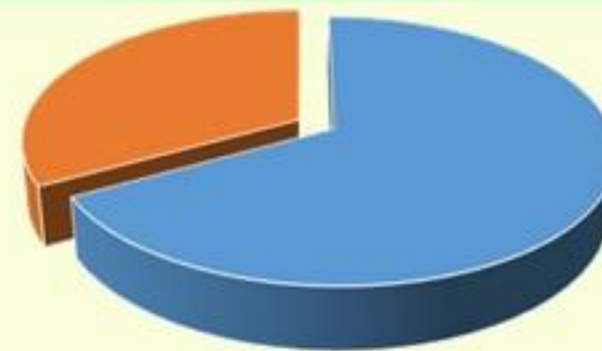


INDIAN SOCIETY

MODULE - 9

STRUCTURAL CHANGE - RURAL SOCIETY

- 1 Indian society is primarily a rural society though urbanization is growing.
- 2 Majority of India's people live in rural areas (69 per cent, according to the 2011 Census).
- 3 Both the culture and social structure in rural India are closely bound up with agricultural and the agrarian way of life.
- 4 Indian village is defined as self-sufficient republics by early sociologists
- 5 Agriculture is the single most important source of livelihood for the majority of the rural population. But the rural is not just agriculture.



■ Rural ■ Urban ■

STRUCTURAL CHANGE - RURAL SOCIETY

6 For example, a large number of artisans such as potters, carpenters, weavers, ironsmiths, and goldsmiths are found in rural areas. They were once part and parcel of the village economy. Their numbers have been steadily lessening since the colonial period.

7 The diversity of occupations in rural India was reflected in the caste system, which in most regions included specialist and 'service' castes such as Washer men, Potters, and Goldsmiths.

8 But increasing interconnection of the rural and urban economies have led to many diverse occupations.

9 Many people living in rural areas are employed in, or have livelihoods based in, rural non-farm activities.



- 10 For instance, there are rural residents employed in government services such as the Postal and Education Departments, factory workers, or in the army, who earn their living through non-agricultural activities.
- 11 The term agrarian structure is often used to refer to the structure or distribution of landholding.
- 12 Because agricultural land is the most important productive resource in rural areas, access to land shapes the rural class structure.
- 13 In each region, there are usually just one or two major landowning dominant castes.
- 14 Examples of dominant landowning groups are the Jats and Rajputs of U.P., the Vokkaligas and Lingayats in Karnataka, Kammas and Reddis in Andhra Pradesh, and Jat Sikhs in Punjab.



THE IMPACT OF LAND REFORMS AFTER INDEPENDENCE

- 1** The policy makers were responding to the dismal agricultural situation in India at that time.
- 2** This was marked by low productivity, dependence on imported food grains, and the intense poverty of a large section of the rural population.
- 3** From the 1950s to the 1970s, a series of land reform laws were passed – at the national level as well as in the states – that were intended to bring about these changes.



THE IMPACT OF LAND REFORMS AFTER INDEPENDENCE

4 The first important legislation was the abolition of the zamindari system, which removed the layer of intermediaries who stood between the cultivators and the state.

a Of all the land reform laws that were passed, this was probably the most effective, for in most areas it succeeded in taking away the superior rights of the zamindars over the land and weakened their economic and political power.

b However, it only removed the top layer of landlords in the multi-layered agrarian structure.



THE IMPACT OF LAND REFORMS AFTER INDEPENDENCE

5 Other major land reform laws that were introduced were the tenancy abolition and regulation acts.

a In most of the states, these laws were never implemented very effectively.

b In West Bengal and Kerala, there was a radical restructuring of the agrarian structure that gave land rights to the tenants.

6 Third major category of land reform laws were the Land Ceiling Acts.

a These laws imposed varied regional upper limit on the amount of land that can be owned by a particular family.

b The state is supposed to identify and take possession of surplus land (above the ceiling limit) held by each household, and redistribute it to landless families and households in other specified categories, such as SCs and STs.



THE IMPACT OF LAND REFORMS AFTER INDEPENDENCE

- 7 On the whole, the agrarian structure, although it has changed substantially from colonial times to the present, remains highly unequal which puts constraints on agricultural productivity.
- 8 Land reforms are necessary not only to boost agricultural growth but also to eradicate poverty in rural areas and bring about social justice.
- 9 Co-operative farming, contractual farming are needed. States should work to develop Farmer producer organisations.



THE GREEN REVOLUTION AND ITS SOCIAL CONSEQUENCES

1 In contrast to land reforms, the Green Revolution of the 1960s and 1970s brought about significant changes in the areas where it took place.

a Government programme of agricultural modernisation.

b funded by international agencies that was based on providing high-yielding variety (HYV) or hybrid seeds along with pesticides, fertilisers, and other inputs, to farmers.

c introduced only in areas that had assured irrigation, because sufficient water was necessary for the new seeds and methods of cultivation.

d targeted mainly at the wheat and rice-growing areas.



THE GREEN REVOLUTION AND ITS SOCIAL CONSEQUENCES

2 As a result, only certain regions such as the Punjab, western U.P., coastal Andhra Pradesh, and parts of Tamil Nadu, received the first wave of the Green Revolution package.

3 Agricultural productivity increased sharply because of the new technology.

4 India was able to become self-sufficient in food grain production for the first time in decades.



THE GREEN REVOLUTION AND ITS SOCIAL CONSEQUENCES

5 Despite these achievements, it also resulted in negative social consequences.

- a Introduction of new technology seemed to be increasing inequalities in rural society.
- b led to the displacement of tenant-cultivators.
- c made the rich farmers better off, and worsened the condition of the landless and marginal holders.
- d Introduction of machinery such as tillers, tractors, threshers, and harvesters (in areas such as Punjab and parts of Madhya Pradesh) led to the displacement of the service caste groups who used to carry out these agriculture-related activities.

e increased the pace of rural-urban migration.



THE GREEN REVOLUTION AND ITS SOCIAL CONSEQUENCES

5 Despite these achievements, it also resulted in negative social consequences. ... *contd*

f rising prices and a shift in the mode of payment of agricultural workers from payment in kind (grain) to cash, actually worsened the economic condition of most rural workers.

g increased livelihood insecurity, as farmers who once grew food for consumption now depend on the market for the incomes.

h switched from a multi-crop system, which allowed them to spread risks, to a mono-crop regime, which means that there is nothing to fall back on in case of crop failure.

i Worsening of regional inequalities.



THE GREEN REVOLUTION AND ITS SOCIAL CONSEQUENCES

6 Much of this knowledge, like the many traditional varieties of seeds that were developed over the centuries by farmers, is being lost as hybrid, high yielding, and genetically modified varieties of seeds are being promoted as more productive and 'scientific'.

7 Adverse environmental impacts



TRANSFORMATIONS IN RURAL SOCIETY AFTER INDEPENDENCE

- 1 Increase in the use of agricultural labour as cultivation became more intensive
- 2 Shift from payment in kind (grain) to payment in cash
- 3 Loosening of traditional bonds or hereditary relationships between farmers or landowners and agricultural workers (known as bonded labour)
- 4 The rise of a class of 'free' wage labourers
- 5 Shift from 'patronage to exploitation'
- 6 Transition to capitalist agriculture.
- 7 As cultivation became more commercialized, these rural areas were also becoming integrated to the wider economy.



TRANSFORMATIONS IN RURAL SOCIETY AFTER INDEPENDENCE

8 This process increased the flow of money into villages and expanding opportunities for business and employment.

9 Well-to-do farmers belonging to the dominant castes began to invest their profits from agriculture in other types of business ventures.

10 This process of diversification gave rise to new entrepreneurial groups that moved out of rural areas and into the growing towns of these developing regions, giving rise to new regional elites that became economically as well as politically dominant.

11 In areas of rapid agricultural development there has been a consolidation of the old landed or cultivating groups, who have transformed themselves into a dynamic entrepreneurial, rural-urban dominant class.



TRANSFORMATIONS IN RURAL SOCIETY AFTER INDEPENDENCE

- 12** But in other regions such as eastern U.P. and Bihar, the lack of effective land reforms, political mobilisation, and redistributive measures has meant that there have been relatively few changes in the agrarian structure and hence in the life conditions of most people.
- 13** In contrast, states such as Kerala have undergone a different process of development, in which political mobilisation, redistributive measures, and linkages to an external economy (primarily the Gulf countries) have brought about a substantial transformation of the rural countryside.
- 14** Far from the rural being primarily agrarian, the rural in Kerala is a mixed economy that integrates some agriculture with a wide network of retail sales and services, and where a large number of families are dependent on remittances from abroad.



- 1 As 'traditional' bonds of patronage between labourers or tenants and landlords broke down, and as the seasonal demand for agricultural labour increased in prosperous Green Revolution regions such as the Punjab, a pattern of seasonal migration emerged
- 2 Labourers migrate also due to the increasing inequalities in rural areas from the mid-1990s, which have forced many households to combine multiple occupations to sustain themselves.
- 3 As a livelihood strategy, men migrate out periodically in search of work and better wages, while women and children are often left behind in their villages with elderly grandparents.
- 4 Migrant workers come mainly from drought-prone and less productive regions, and they go to work for part of the year on farms in the Punjab and Haryana, or on brick kilns in U.P., or construction sites in cities such as New Delhi or Bangalore.



CIRCULATION OF LABOUR

5 Wealthy farmers often prefer to employ migrant workers for harvesting and other such intensive operations, rather than the local working class, because migrants are more easily exploited and can be paid lower wages.

6 This preference has produced a peculiar pattern in some areas where the local landless labourers move out of the home villages in search of work during the peak agricultural seasons, while migrant workers are brought in from other areas to work on the local farms.

7 Migration and lack of job security have created very poor working and living conditions for these workers.



CIRCULATION OF LABOUR

8 Economic Survey 2017-18 says that with growing rural to urban migration by men, there is 'feminisation' of agriculture sector, with increasing number of women in multiple roles as cultivators, entrepreneurs, and labourers.

9 As per OXFAM report, In India, 85% of rural women are engaged in agriculture, yet only about 13% own land.

10 The situation is worse in Bihar with only 7% women having land rights, though women play an important role in various agricultural activities.

11 70% of all women engaged in cultivation are from households witnessing migration.



GLOBALISATION, LIBERALISATION, AND RURAL SOCIETY

- 1 The policy of liberalisation that India has been following since the late 1980s has had a very significant impact on agriculture and rural society.
- 2 After decades of state support and protected markets, Indian farmers have been exposed to competition from the global market.
- 3 For instance, imported fruits and other food items on the shelves of our local stores – items that were not available a few years ago because of import barriers.
- 4 Recently, India has also decided to import wheat, a controversial decision that reverses the earlier policy of self-reliance in food grains.
- 5 These indicate the process of globalisation of agriculture, or the incorporation of agriculture into the larger global market – a process that has had direct effects on farmers and rural society.



GLOBALISATION, LIBERALISATION, AND RURAL SOCIETY

- 6 For instance, in some regions such as Punjab and Karnataka, farmers enter into **contracts with multinational companies** (such as PepsiCo) to grow certain crops (such as tomatoes and potatoes), which the companies then buy from them for processing or export.
- 7 In **'contract farming' systems**, the **company identifies the crop to be grown**, **provides the seeds and other inputs**, as well as the **knowhow** and often also the **working capital**.
- 8 In return, the **farmer is assured of a market** because the company guarantees that it will purchase the produce at a **predetermined fixed price**.



GLOBALISATION, LIBERALISATION, AND RURAL SOCIETY

9

Despite the financial security to farmers, it leads to

- a insecurity as farmers become dependent on these companies for their livelihoods.
- b agricultural land is diverted away from food grain production for export-oriented products such as flowers and gherkins
- c disengages many people from the production process and makes their own indigenous knowledge of agriculture irrelevant.
- d primarily to the production of elite items
- e As it requires high doses of fertilisers and pesticides, it is often not ecologically sustainable.



GLOBALISATION, LIBERALISATION, AND RURAL SOCIETY

10 Entry of multinationals into this sector as sellers of agricultural inputs such as seeds, pesticides, and fertilisers led to the increased dependence of farmers on expensive fertilisers and pesticides.

11 While farmers in India for centuries have periodically faced distress due to drought, crop failures, or debt, the phenomenon of farmers' suicides appears to be new.



FARMERS SUICIDES

1 The spate of farmers' suicides that has been occurring in different parts of the country since 1997-98 can be linked to the 'agrarian distress' caused by structural changes in agriculture and changes in economic and agricultural policies.

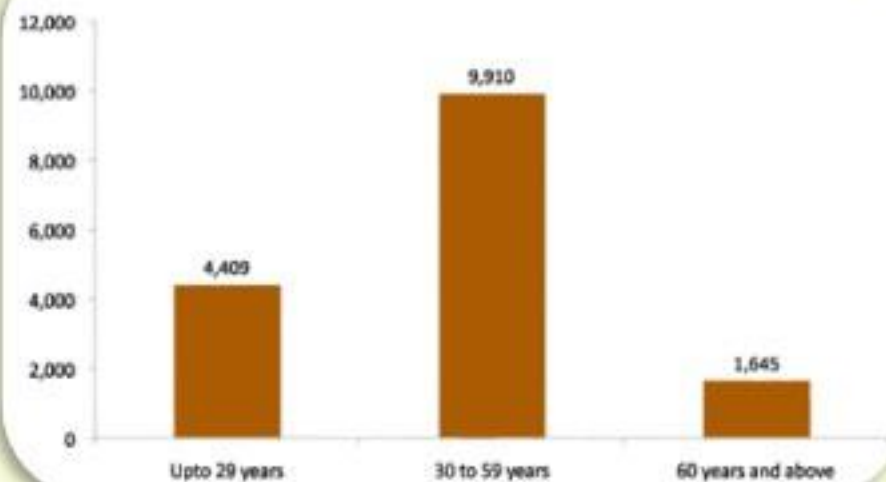
- a** the changed pattern of landholdings
- b** changing cropping patterns, especially due to shift to cash crops
- c** liberalisation policies that have exposed Indian agriculture to the forces of globalization.
- d** heavy dependence on high-cost inputs



FARMERS SUICIDES

- e withdrawal of the State from agricultural extension activities to be replaced by multinational seed and fertiliser companies; decline in state support for agriculture.
- f individualisation of agricultural operations
- g unable to bear the debt burden or sustain their families.
- h distress is compounded by the changing culture in rural areas, in which increased incomes are required for marriages, dowries and to sustain new activities and expenses, such as education and medical care

Age classification of suicide victims



FARMERS SUICIDES

2 According to official statistics, 45 farmers commit suicide each day in India.

- Five most affected states are Maharashtra ,Karnataka ,Andhra Pradesh , Madhya Pradesh and Chattisgarh

3 Agriculture for many is becoming untenable, and state support for agriculture has declined substantially.

4 In addition, agricultural issues are no longer key public issues, and lack of mobilisation means that agriculturists are unable to form powerful pressure groups that can influence policy making in their favour.

5 Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana, Gram Uday se Bharat Uday Abhiyan, PM Kisan, and National Rurban Mission are some of the schemes of the Government of India, which may provide unified help to farmers all over the country.



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